60.

I WALKED home from the office and found Meg sitting on the stairs.

She was sobbing. Uncontrollably.

My love, what's happened?

I thought for sure we'd lost the baby.

I went to her on my knees. She choked out that she didn't want to do this anymore.

Do what?

Live.

I didn't catch her meaning at first. I didn't understand, maybe didn't want to understand. My mind just didn't want to process the words.

It's all so painful, she was saying.

What is?

To be hated like this—for what?

What had she *done*? she asked. She really wanted to know. What sin had she committed to deserve this kind of treatment?

She just wanted to make the pain stop, she said. Not only for her, for everyone. For me, for her mother. But she *couldn't* make it stop, so she'd decided to disappear.

Disappear?

Without her, she said, all the press would go away, and then I wouldn't have to live like this. Our unborn child would never have to live like this.

It's so clear, she kept saying, *it's so clear. Just stop breathing. Stop being. This exists because I exist.*

I begged her not to talk like that. I promised her we'd get through it, we'd find a way. In the meantime, we'd find her the help she needed.

I asked her to be strong, hang on.

Incredibly, while reassuring her, and hugging her, I couldn't entirely stop thinking like a *fucking royal*. We had a Sentebale engagement that night, at the Royal Albert Hall, and I kept telling myself: We can't be late. We *cannot* be late. They'll skin us alive! And they'll blame her.

Slowly—too slowly—I realized that tardiness was the least of our problems.